

Chapter 2

To be or to become, that is the question: Word formation of the weak verbs formed from color adjectives in Old West Norse

Ramón Boldt

Friedrich-Alexander-Universität Erlangen-Nürnberg

This article examines the semantic properties of a group of twelve Old West Norse deadjectival weak verbs, namely those derived from the eight Basic Color Terms that are attested in this language. The data is drawn from five major Old West Norse dictionaries. This way, it can be shown that the three class I *jan*-verbs which are of Proto-Germanic origin share factitive semantics. The six genuinely Nordic class II *nan*-verbs share anticausative-inchoative semantics. The three class II *ōn*-verbs, however, are diverse in semantics and age. It can further be shown that the lack of context typical for dictionaries nurtures semantic imprecisions and inconsistencies, which can be met by investigating the original sources.

1 Introduction and aims

In what follows, I will present some initial considerations as part of an ongoing project on Old West Norse (OWN) verbal word formation. As the Vienna workshop focused on deadjectival verb formation, the topic of this paper is the formation of weak verbs to color adjectives. For this purpose, I have mainly evaluated some of the larger Old West Norse dictionaries (Section 3). Underlining the shortcomings of this method in comparison to working with corpora with regard to issues of *Aktionsart* (hence “to be or to become” in the title) has also been a goal of the talk and, subsequently, of this article.



2 Basic Color Terms

With respect to color adjectives, it is not possible to cover all words for colors that are attested in Old West Norse texts for reasons of space. Therefore, the selection will be limited to the so-called Basic Color Terms, a term well established since Berlin & Kay 1969 (*Basic Color Terms: Their Universality and Evolution*). In the most recent investigation, Jackson Crawford's dissertation *The Historical Development of Basic Color Terms in Old Norse-Icelandic* (Crawford 2014), the author provides a selection of color terms that can be considered basic in Old West Norse.¹ Crawford himself refers to the latest comprehensive study of the topic, Biggam (2012). Here is not the place to discuss their concept of Basic Color Term (BCT) in length. Instead, I will present the most important criteria according to Crawford (2014: 125–153) and Biggam (2012: 21–42) in order to motivate the focus on a certain class of color adjectives in this article. In principle, I follow both authors, but not always rigidly, and I deviate from their criteria when it serves my purpose of elucidating matters of verbal word formation.

- a) The color term in question must be monolexemic, i.e., a simplex. It must therefore not be deducible from the sum of its parts. In other words, it must be non-predictable. Most of the complex color terms in Old West Norse seem to be *ad hoc* formations, attested only once or twice, e.g., *móbrúnn* 'dark brown' or *iðjagrónn* 'green again (?)'. However, it can be argued that those compounds could only have been formed on the assumption that readers must have been able to predict their meaning.²
- b) The color term in question must not be a hyponym. Crawford (2014: 59) is "hesitant" in ascribing basic status to OWN *brúnn* 'brown'. He rather considers it a contextually restricted hyponym for *svartr* 'black', as it is used only to describe a certain dark hue of hair, especially horse hair. In other words, a horse with *brúna* hair can also be described as having *svarta* hair. Nonetheless, I will make some brief remarks on OWN *brúnn* here as well, because it is important for issues related to word formation.

¹For a similar approach, cf. Wolf (2013), Brückmann (2012), Wolf (2006a). For the Non-Basic Color Terms in Old West Norse, cf. Wolf (2015).

²Crawford (2014: 126) discusses the compound *skolbrúnn*, which he translates as "dirty water brown" or perhaps "dirty-water (eye)browed". In light of similar compounds like *léttbrúnn* 'light-browed (i.e., happy looking)' and *hvítbrúnn* 'white-browed', it seems to me that this can not be taken as a good example here.

- c) Related to b) is the idea that the use of a color term in question must not be restricted to a class of objects. A good example can be seen in German and English *blond* which can only be used to describe the human hair color.³
- d) BCTs are morphologically more productive than other color terms. For example, in contemporary English, we see that only *red*, *black*, and *white* can serve as bases for anticausative-inchoative derivations: *red*den, *black*en, and *whiten*. This could, as we will see, be true for Old West Norse as well in that at least one derivative is attested for every BCT.
- e) Finally, a lexeme in question must contain information about hue, that is “the spectrum of visible light, parts of which, according to their wavelength or frequency, are perceived by humans to differ from others” (Biggam 2012: 3). Lexemes that only contain information on saturation or tone, that is “the admixture of white or black with a hue” (ibid.), are excluded. An example from OWN would be *døkk*r ‘dark’, which is neutral in respect to hue. However, OWN *bleik*r, often translated as ‘pale’ in the dictionaries or conceptualized as “macrocolor covering, at least partly, the category of pale of light colors” (Wolf 2013: 143), is part of Crawford’s investigation as he favors it over *gul*r as the BCT for ‘yellow’. I follow him in that regard.

In light of what we have established so far, the following color terms will be considered basic in Old West Norse: *blár* ‘blue, black’; *bleik*r ‘yellow’; *brúnn* ‘brown’; *grár* ‘grey’; *grónn* ‘green’; *hvít*r ‘white’; *rauð*r resp. *rjóð*r ‘red’; *svartr* ‘black’. Accordingly, the verbal word formation of those color adjectives will be the focus of this article.

3 Sources

As mentioned in Section 1, I focus on dictionaries here in order to highlight the shortcomings of this method in comparison to working with corpora, namely the sometimes imprecise determination of the semantics of the respective verbs. The following dictionaries were used:

- Cleasby’s and Vigfússon’s *Old Norse to English Dictionary* (from now on CV),

³In contrast to OWN *brúnn* : *svartr*, English and German *blond* is usually not considered a hyponym of, say, *gelb* or *yellow*, respectively.

- Baetke's *Wörterbuch zur altnordischen Prosaliteratur* (WAP),
- Fritzner's *Ordbog over det gamle norske Sprog* (OgnS),
- and the not yet completed *Dictionary of Old Norse Prose* (ONP).

The last one is certainly more than a mere dictionary in that it contextualizes the words in question and provides scans of the relevant editions of those texts in which the words are attested. Weak verbs from the poetic language recorded in the *Lexicon Poeticum* (LP) do not provide any substantial additional information regarding the questions discussed here. The LP will therefore be quoted only occasionally.

4 History of research

In comparison to the other Old Germanic languages, we know relatively little about verbal word formation in Old (West) Norse, although researchers have long taken a keen interest in the language.⁴ In the early Neogrammarian period, research focused mainly on formal aspects of verbal inflection. Noreen (1923) – considered the standard reference grammar for Old West Norse until today – does not mention word formation at all. The same is true for other grammars and surveys from that era (Wimmer 1871; Brenner 1882; Heusler 1932; Krause 1948; Andersen 1954). In contrast, Holthausen (1895) seems to be the first to discuss the verbal word formation of Old West Norse. He does so on one page in a chapter entitled *Bildungslehre* (131). Here, Holthausen is mostly concerned with the *jan*-suffix that, according to him, primarily forms causatives from strong ablauting verbs, for example, *føra* 'to lead, transport, move' from *fara* 'to go, travel, fare'.⁵ Additionally, the class II *ōn*-suffix forms denominatives, e.g., *tala* 'to speak' from *tal* 'talk, conversation; speech, language'. Also, class II contains *nan*-verbs of the former class IV, e.g., *vakna* 'wake up' in contrast to *vaka* 'being awake, waking'. Holthausen describes those verbs as passive and inchoative, a view still upheld by some researchers.⁶

⁴For Gothic see Marti Heinzle (2023), García García (2005); for Old English see Bammesberger (1965); for Old High German see Marti Heinzle (2019), Riecke (1996); for Middle High German see Leipold (2006); for Early New High German see Habermann (1994); for Old Frisian see Marti Heinzle (2014); for a comparative study on Gothic and Continental West Germanic see Schwerdt (2008).

⁵Still visible today in Nynorsk *å føra* : *å fara* or German *führen* : *fahren*.

⁶In light of more recent research, it is argued that the class-forming feature of the *nan*-verbs is not inchoativity (i.e., the verb denotes the (gradual) beginning of a situation) and/or pas-

Class IV exists as such only in Gothic. In West Germanic, these verbs joined class II or class III (in Old High German). A few *nan*-verbs may be attested in Proto-Norse, but their readings and interpretations must be considered uncertain.⁷ Moreover, it is difficult to determine whether they formed a separate class.

The path of research that began with Holthausen (1895) seems to have reached its climax with Wessén's (1965) *Svensk språkhistoria: Ordbildningslära*. Wessén was comprehensive in his analysis, writing for almost 20 pages on Norse verbal formation (90–107). However, we are still rather limited in what we know compared to other older Germanic languages (see fn. 4). Except for the field's current focus on the former class IV verbs, the state of research seems to be condensed in Nedoma's (2010: 118–120) *Kleine Grammatik des Altisländischen*. According to Nedoma, the three weak classes of Old West Norse entail the following semantic properties:

- class I (*i*)*jan*-verbs: deverbal causatives, denominal factitives, and some intensive-iteratives
- class II *ōn*-verbs: denominals of various kinds, as well as some intensive-iteratives
- class III *ēn*-verbs: mainly intransitive duratives.

5 Weak verbs attested in Old West Norse

5.1 General remarks

In what follows, I will evaluate the semantics of the Old West Norse weak verbs formed to BCTs as given in the dictionaries listed above and examine whether their translations correspond to what is discussed in the reference grammars and handbooks. In OHG, we can witness a decreasing correlation between semantic

sivity, but anticausativity (i.e., the verb denotes a situation where the subject is non-agentive, often relating to internal and external nature), cf. Scheungraber (2014); Ottósson (2013); also Villanueva Svensson (2011). Haspelmath (1987: 16–17) seems to be the first to explicitly refer to the Gothic *nan*-verbs as anticausative. Gorbachov's (2007) study on the nasal presents in Germanic, Slavic, and Baltic does not make use of the term *anticausative* but calls this class *inchoative*. See the introduction of this volume on the different uses of these terms in the context of deadjectival verb formation in general.

⁷Cf. PN *hleunan** 'to become warm' (cf. Boldt 2024), *sufnan** 'to start moving', *dwenan** 'to dwindle'.

classes and certain morphemes, a process coming to an end in MHG, where the suffixes merely function as purely morphological markers of inflection.⁸

I will present the BCTs (as mentioned in Section 2) one after another in alphabetical order. I will also present their meaning, cognates in the other Old Germanic languages, basic etymological information, and finally the weak verbs derived from them. I will then give the meaning of those verbs as posited in the dictionaries as well as representative examples of their actual occurrences. In most cases, the meanings provided by the dictionaries agree with one another. However, there are some instances where the provided meanings are inconsistent. In examples of the latter, I will try to provide a solution based on the actual texts.

5.2 *blár* ‘blue, blue-black; black; dark’

The first BCT to be presented here is *blár* ‘blue; blue-black; black; dark’.⁹ It is well attested in the other Old Germanic languages, cf. OE in *blæ-hæwen* ‘of a blue hue, bluish’ and *blæwen* ‘light blue’, OHG *blāo*, OFris. *blāu*, OS *blāo* < PG **blēwa*- ‘blue’, and connected to Lat. *flāvus* and OIr. *blā*, although the exact circumstances are not entirely clear (cf. EWA II 160; EDPG 68; EWGP 135; Lühr 2000: 63).

Regarding verbal derivations of *blár*, only one weak verb is attested in Germanic in general, and in OWN in particular. It is the verb *blána* that belongs to the former class IV, but synchronically to class II. It is also attested in OSwed. *blana*. According to ONP, the verb is attested at least 13 times in OWN prose. With regard to the meaning of this verb, the dictionaries agree: They all imply anticausative-inchoative semantics.¹⁰

- ONP: ‘to turn black-and-blue, take on a livid color’
- CV: ‘to become black, livid’
- WAP: ‘dunkel werden, eine dunkle Farbe annehmen, blauschwarz werden’
- OgnS: ‘blive blaa’ (‘to become blue’)

An example for this use of *blána* is given in (1):

⁸MhdGr III: 494–496; Boldt (2023: 109–111).

⁹For a detailed study on the use of *blár*, also in comparison to *svartr*, in Old Icelandic, cf. Wolf (2006b).

¹⁰As stated in fn. 6, in more recent research the anticausative character of (former) *nan*-verbs is favored over the earlier assumption of primarily inchoative semantics. As this issue is not decisive here, I will stick with the term anticausative-inchoative, cf. Villanueva Svensson (2011).

The second weak verb derived from *bleikr* is OWN *blikna*. Just like *blána*, it is a class II verb with anticausative-inchoative semantics, earlier associated with the fourth class. As with *blána*, it is attested only in OWN (at least 30 times according to ONP, twice according to LP).¹² In addition, *blikna* is one of the zero-grade derivations from a strong verb well attested in OWN,¹³ namely from OWN *blíkja* ‘to glisten, glint’ (< **bleikan-* with secondary palatalization, see AnGr §362). This makes it likely that this is a purely Norse innovation.

In this case, the dictionaries again agree on the semantics of the verb in question:

- ONP: ‘to turn pale, turn sallow’
- CV: ‘to become pale’
- WAP: ‘blass werden, erbleichen’
- OgnS: ‘blegne, blive hvid eller bleg’ (‘to become pale, become white or sallow’)

(3) Óláfs saga helga 173,13

þa blicna-ði hann oc varð faul-r sem
 then **turn.sallow**-3SG.PRET he and become.3SG.PRET pale-NOM.SG like
nár
 corpse

‘He then **turned sallow** and became pale like a corpse.’

Apart from *blikna*, we have another class II verb belonging to *bleikr* in OWN, namely *blika*. In contrast to *blikna*, it is an old *ōn*-verb, going back to PG **blikōn-*, as attested in OSwed. *blika*, OE *blician* (AEW 44), another zero-grade formation of **bleikan-*. In contrast to the aforementioned verbal formations, the dictionaries disagree with each other in this case:

- ONP: ‘to glisten, glint, shine’
- CV: ‘to gleam, twinkle’
- WAP: ‘blinken, funkeln’ but also ‘erglänzen, aufblitzen’

¹²Cf. Middle English *bliknen* ‘to become pale’ is a loan from OWN showing anticausative-inchoative semantics as well.

¹³On that type, cf. Ottósson (2013: 344) with literature.

- OgnS: = *blikja* ‘shine, gleam’
- LP: ‘gleam, flash’

Already Krahe & Meid (1969: 240) stated that the old deverbal *ōn*-verbs are predominantly of intensive-iterative character, which would be confirmed by the derivation’s meaning ‘to glisten, glint’ with regard to a verbal base **bleikan-* ‘to gleam, shimmer’. The entry in WAP, however, would suggest an additional inchoative or rather semelfactive meaning ‘to flash’. To address this problem, I have examined the actual attestations. According to ONP, *blika* is attested at least 10 times in the corpus of Old West Norse prose. Strikingly, in 9 out of those 10 attestations *blika* refers to *skildir* ‘shields’, and the combination of both might be regarded as a fixed expression.¹⁴ In light of this information, a classification of *bleikr* ‘pale; (light) yellow’ as BCT might seem questionable, because it contradicts the fact that a BCT must not be restricted to a class of objects. As I cannot discuss this matter in detail here, I will keep the focus on issues of verbal word formation and therefore quote two passages:

(4) Njáls saga 210,27

... *Skild-ir* ***blik-a...***, *er* *sól-in* *skin-n* *á ...*
 shield-NOM.PL ***blika***-3PL.PRS which sun.NOM.SG-DET shine-3SG.PRS on
 ‘The shields ***blika***, on which the sun shines ...’

(5) Heiðarvígá saga 99,16

... *skip* *skrið-r*, *skild-ir* ***blik-a***
 ship.NOM.SG glide-3SG.PRS shield-NOM.PL ***blika***-3PL.PRS
sol-skin *sne* *leg-ir*
 sun-shine.NOM.SG snow.ACC.SG melt-3SG.PRS
 ‘[Whoever breaks an oath is outlawed as long as Christians go to church,
 fires blaze, fields green], ship glides, shields ***blika***, sunshine melts snow.’

Neither of the two text passages can help us in determining the semantic value of *blika* as intensive or semelfactive, since both are decidedly ambiguous.

The second text passage in (5) is cited here additionally in order to draw attention to the shortcomings of working with very limited contexts. The entry given in the ONP consists of nothing more than *skildir blika*. Though this is more than

¹⁴A fixed order of the two components could also account for the verb fronting in example sentences (6) and (7). On the other hand, the three attestations of *blika* given in LP from the poetic texts are not combined with *skildir*, but with *merki* ‘banners’, *vôpn* ‘weapons’, and *reiði* ‘harness’.

what we get from the other dictionaries, it still can hardly be called context at all. Luckily, this problem is resolved by the ONP, which provides detailed information on where to find the passage in question in the edition as well as a scan of that very passage.

The other passages are not helpful in further determining the semantic value of *blika*. To illustrate this claim I will quote another two of them:

- (6) Egils saga 159,17

Menn sa af þinginu at flock-r manna
 one saw from thing.DAT.SG.DET at crowd-NOM.SG man.GEN.SG
reið neðan ... ok bliku-ðu þar skild-er við
 ride.3SG.PRET down and blika-3PL.PRET there shield-NOM.PL with
 ‘One saw from the Thing a crowd of men riding down ... and there their shields *blikuðu* ...’

- (7) Bolla þátrr 299,18

Eða hvat sé ek þar upp kom-a, blik-a þar eigi
 but what see.1SG I there up come-INF blika-3SG.PRS there not
skild-ir við?
 shield-NOM.PL with
 ‘But what do I see coming up there, aren’t there shields *blika*?’

In the second example, *upp koma* ‘to come up, appear’ in the first of the two asyndetically connected main clauses conveys an inchoative sense of the situation. In my view, this might even speak against a semelfactive reading of the second main clause and therefore of *blika*. As I can see coming up a thunderstorm, but not the lightning that comes with it, I can see coming up a troop of soldiers, but not the flashing of their shields.

Whatever one might think about this question of detail, it seems clear that an unambiguous choice between reading *blika* as intensive-iterative ‘to glisten, glint’ or as inchoative resp. semelfactive ‘to flash’ is hardly possible on grounds of the texts that have come down to us. We find ourselves amidst, on the one hand, interpretations that are read into the texts retrospectively and, on the other hand, semantic overlaps that are an integral part of the actual language studied and every language in general.

5.4 *brúnn* ‘brown, dark brown; brownish-violet’

As there is no class III weak verb of *bleika* attested, I shall proceed to the next color adjective on the list, i.e., *brúnn* ‘brown, dark brown; brownish-violet’.¹⁵ With OE, OS, OHG, and OFris. *brūn*, it can be traced back to PG **brūna-* (EWA II 374; EWGP 143).

A class I verb is not attested in OWN, but in OHG there is *brūnen* ‘to make brown-violet, purple; to give colorfulness’ (only in Notker), to be read as /brynen/ with not yet graphically realized *i*-Umlaut, cf. MHG *briunen*, German *bräunen*.

As for class II in OWN, the expected OWN *brúna** ‘to become brown’ is not actually attested. Interestingly, the adjective *brúnaðr* ‘brown colored’ is attested at least 17 times in the OWN prose texts (according to ONP). The existence of this adjective presupposes that at some earlier point in time *brúna** must have been a verb that either vanished or just happens not to occur in the texts we know.¹⁶

5.5 *grár* ‘grey; hostile’

Derivations of OWN *grár* ‘grey’, also ‘hostile’,¹⁷ are comparably sparse. Because of OHG *grāo*, OS *-grē* (only in *appulgrē* ‘grey spotted, piebald [about a horse]’), Langob. **grāus*, Goth. **grēwa*, we know that there must have been PG **grēwa-* (with **grēw-ija-* > OE *græg*), another *wa*-adjective just like the words for ‘blue’ and ‘yellow’ (EWA IV 591; EWGP 259; Lühr 2000: 265–266; EDPG 189).

No class I verb is attested to this adjective. OHG *grāwēn* is a class III verb that surfaces only in the glosses. Typical for OHG verbs of this class, it vacillates between inchoative and durative semantics and therefore would have to be translated as ‘to become grey’ and/or ‘to be grey; shimmer’.

In OWN, again, there is a class II verb attested only here, namely *grána*. According to the dictionaries, it shows predominantly metaphoric semantics:

- ONP: ‘to develop badly (between someone), take a serious turn’
- CV: ‘to become grey, metaph. to be coarse and spiteful’
- WAP: ‘(eigentlich grau werden) unfreundlich werden’

¹⁵For a detailed study on the use of *brúnn* in Old Icelandic, cf. Wolf (2017).

¹⁶Crawford (2014: 132, Fn. 30) states: “A verb *bruna* does exist in ModNorw, but it does not have inchoative meaning”. This is indeed the case, but the way Crawford puts it is rather misleading. There is a verb *brune/-a*, but according to ordbønene.no, it has factitive semantics ‘gjøre brun’.

¹⁷For a detailed study on the use of *grár* in Old Icelandic, cf. Wolf (2009).

- OgnS: ‘blive graa, antage en graa Farve’ (‘to become grey, take on a grey color’)
- LP: ‘fade away’

The semantics in the ONP are given based on the following example:

(8) Sturlunga saga 20,7

Ok af þess-um ákøst-um tek-r heldr at
 and from this-DAT.PL provocation-DAT.PL begin-3SG.PRS rather to
gran-a gaman-it, ok kom-a
 take.a.serious.turn-INF pleasure.NOM.SG-DET and come-INF
kviðling-ar við svá
 mocking.verse-NOM.PL with so

‘... and because of these provocations the pleasure began to rather **take a serious turn** and mocking verses were added.’

5.6 *grónn* ‘green’

Somewhat surprisingly, only one verbal derivation to OWN *grónn* ‘green’ is reflected in the texts. The adjective itself has parallels in OE, OFris. *grēne*, OS *grōni*, OHG *gruoni* and can therefore be said to continue an older PG **grōni*- (EWA IV: 667; EWGP 260–261; EDPG 191–192).

It is the second time that we encounter a class I verb: *grōna*. According to ONP s.v. *grōna*, it is attested only once, as medio-passive *grønask*. It surfaces in the Flórents saga as a 3sg. preterit form <græniz> with the ending -iz from earlier (but in this particular case unattested) -isk (AnGr §544,2). Perhaps because it is attested only once in the prose texts (and not at all in the poetic texts), ONP and CV agree in their translation, while OgnS does not list the verb:

- ONP and CV: ‘blive grøn’ (‘to become green’)

Mindful of the fact that we are dealing here with a medio-passive class I verb, we could expect a reflexive factitive meaning ‘to make oneself green’. But who or what is capable of doing such a thing? The solution becomes apparent if we have a look at the actual paragraph:

(9) Flórents saga 197,53

... þa leinga-z dag-ar, ok batna-r
 then lengthen-3SG.PRS.REFL day-NOM.PL and improve-3SG.PRS

vedratta **græni-z** *jord* ...
 weather.NOM.SG **make.green**-3SG.PRS.REFL earth.NOM.SG
 ‘... the days get longer, and the weather improves, the earth **makes itself green** (= becomes green) ...’

If one believes that the earth is referred to as an animate entity here and is therefore not only the subject of the clause, but also the agent, then the use of *græni-z* would be strictly reflexive. If, on the other hand, this is not the case, it would point to anticausative semantics, since *jord* ‘earth’ is still the subject of the clause, but not the agent. As the patient, becoming green is something that happens to it.¹⁸

Class III verbs are attested only for OE *grēnian* ‘to become green (about foliage); flourish’, and OHG *gruonēn* ‘to become / to be green, blossom, flourish’ again with the vacillation between inchoative/ingressive and durative meaning so characteristic for OHG class III verbs.

5.7 *hvítr* ‘white’

Continuations of PG **h^weita-* ‘white’ are widely attested. Next to OWN *hvítr* we have West Germanic cognates OE *hwīt*, OHG (*h*)*wīz*, OFris. (*h*)*wīt*, *wit*, and even Goth. *hveits* (EWGP 316–317; EDPG 267).

A Proto-Germanic factitive **h^weitijan-* can be assumed based on OE *hwītan* ‘to make white, to whiten; to polish’, OHG (*h*)*wizen* ‘idem; also: to wash white’, and Goth. *gahweitjan* ‘to make white, to whiten’. It is, however, not attested in OWN.¹⁹

According to the findings so far, we have yet another class II *nan*-verb *hvítna* that is restricted to OWN. Again, the dictionaries agree on the meaning:

- ONP: ‘blive hvid’ (‘to become white’)
- CV: ‘to become white’
- WAP: ‘weiß werden’
- OgnS: ‘blive hvid’ (‘to become white’)

¹⁸This matter cannot be decided on the basis of the text. There are references in Old Norse sources (especially the translation of the *Elucidarius*, and the *Edda*) to the equation common in the Middle Ages of a man as a microcosm with the macrocosm, whereby the four major elements earth, water, air and fire correspond to human flesh, blood, breath and body heat, cf. Simek (1990: 94–95) and *passim*.

¹⁹An online search in the ONP for the definitions ‘to make white’ or ‘whiten’ does not yield a single result.

- (10) Snorra Edda 49,22

hann herþ-i hendrn-ar at hamar-skapt-i-nv, sv
 he clasp.firmly-3SG.PRET hand-NOM.PL at hammer-shaft-DET-DAT.SG so
at hvitnv-þv knv-ar-nir
 that become.white-3PL.PRET knuckle-NOM.PL-DET
 ‘He clasped the hammer shaft so firmly with his hands that his knuckles
 became white.’

Interestingly, the dictionaries contradict one another with respect to verbs attested in OE *hwítian* (class II) and OHG *wīzēn* (class III). According to AEW 273, neither of them is inchoative. According to BT s.v. *hwítian*, however, the English verb vacillates between ‘to be / to become white’. The same is true for the OHG verb. While Schützeichel (2012: 397) translates it as inchoative ‘weiß werden’, Heidermanns (EWGP 317) suggests ‘weiß werden, sein’. This, again, illustrates that, when it comes to semantics, working with dictionaries can be a venture that should be approached with caution.

5.8 *rauðr* and *rjóðr* ‘red’

We shall now deal with derivations of the words for ‘red’. In addition to OWN *rauðr*, a second lexeme *rjóðr* is attested in the texts as well. While *rauðr* is the common word (at least 248 instances according to ONP, and 112 according to LP), *rjóðr* is “extremely uncommon [and] used only for the color of human faces” (Crawford 2014: 120).

OWN *rauðr* can formally be traced back to PG **rauda-* ‘red’, as shown by OE *rēad*, OFris. *rād*, OS *rōd*, OHG *rōt*, and Goth. *rauþs*. OWN *rjóðr* on the other hand belongs to the ablauting PG **reuda-* ‘red’, in turn shown by OE *rēod*, and Goth. *gariuþs* ‘honorable’ (< ‘shameful’ < ‘with a red face’), EWA VII 653–654; EWGP 438–439, 448; Lühr (2000: 71).²⁰

If we now take a closer look at the weak verbs, we find *roðna* and *roða* (both class II). The first one is translated by the dictionaries as having anticausative-inchoative semantics:

²⁰It has been suggested (EWGP 448), that PG **reuda-* ‘red’ is a Germanic innovation to the present stem of a strong verb PG **reuda-* ‘to make red’, but Ved. *rōhita-* ‘red (adj.); red horse (subs.)’, Av. *raoðita-* ‘red’, and Lat. *rūbidus* < **h₁re/ouð^h-i-* (EWA VII: 655) show that there was an old *e/o*-ablauting adjective of which both forms survived in Germanic and were therefore directly ancestral to **reuda-* as well as **rauda-*. Moreover, there must have been a zero-grade *ró*-derivative **h₁rud^h-ró-* (> Latin *ruber*, Greek *ἐρυθρός* ‘red’) that gave rise to PG **rudra-*. As this only survives as an *ōn*-stem feminine noun OWN *roðra* ‘blood’, it can be disregarded here.

- ONP: –
- CV: ‘to redden, become red (of the face), to blush’
- WAP: ‘rot werden, erröten’
- OgnS: ‘rødme, blive rød; blive rød i Kinderne’ (‘to blush, become red; to turn red in the cheeks’)

An example for the use of *roðna* (as 3SG.PRET *rodnaþi* ‘(she) blushed’) can be seen below in (12).

Less clear, on the other hand, is the derivational history of this word. No cognates in the other Germanic languages suggest that it might be an OWN innovation. According to Wessén (1965: 100), all it takes for a word *roðna* to be built is the need for finite verb forms with the meaning ‘to become red’ and a sample group (“Mönstergrupp”) that can serve as a model. As we have seen, the other OWN weak *nan*-verbs formed to color adjectives have no correspondences in the other Germanic languages. It can thus be assumed that the pattern was productive in OWN.

Seebold (1970: 379), however, states that *roðna* ‘rot werden, sich röten’ is derived from the strong verb PG **reuda-* ‘röten’. Heidermanns’ etymological dictionary of the Germanic primary adjectives does not contain *nō*-derivatives neither s.v. *rauda-* ‘rot’ (EWGP 438–439) nor s.v. *reuda-* ‘gerötet’ (EWGP 448). He therefore seems to assume that OWN *roðna* is of deverbal origin as well.

If we were to assume that OWN *roðna* continues a *voreinzelsprachliche* formation, we could not decide if it was deverbal from **reuda-* ‘redde(n)’ or deadjectival from either **rauda-* ‘red’ or **reuda-* ‘reddened’ on formal or semantic grounds. On the formal side, all three possibilities would require a zero-grade root and the subsequent development **rud-nō- > *rud-na- > roðna*.

On the semantic side, if we recall the anticausative-inchoative function of the *nō*-formations, a deverbal formation to **reuda-* would yield ‘to become reddened’,²¹ and a deadjectival formation would yield ‘to become red’ or ‘to become reddened’.

Given that there are no cognates in the other Germanic languages and that former *nō*-formations were productive in OWN, the assumption that *roðna* is indeed an innovation seems to be the most plausible.

In addition to *roðna* there is, as stated above, another class II weak verb: *roða*. No translation is given in the ONP yet, but the other dictionaries do not contradict one another regarding the meaning of the verb:

²¹Cf. Goth. *us-brukan* ‘to become broken off’ : *brikan* ‘to break’, OWN. *sofna* ‘to fall asleep’ : *sofa* ‘to sleep’, see Krahe & Meid (1969: 253) for further examples.

- CV: ‘to gleam red’
- WAP: ‘roten Schein geben, rot leuchten’
- OgnS: ‘kaste et rødt Skin, en rød Farve fra sig eller over noget’ (‘to cast a red light, a red color from oneself or at something’)

In the Germanic etymological dictionaries, *roða* is usually reconstructed as a class III verb **rudēn-* (> OHG *rotēn* ‘to be or become red’, AEW 450; EDPG 416; EWA VII 658). While this is formally possible, the attested Old West Norse forms, however, synchronically show class II inflection. According to ONP, the verb is attested at least twice in the Old West Norse prose literature. There are, however, no attestations in the poetic texts. Two of the attestations are given in examples (11)-(12) below.

- (11) Sverris saga 92,29

Sva var at sia i fiall-it upp sem i log-a
 so was to look.INF at rock.NOM.SG-DET up like in fire-ACC.SG
sei, er roða-ði sciolld-unum
 look.3SG.PST.SBJV that gleam.red-3SG.PRET shield-DAT.PL
 ‘Looking up at the rock that gleamed red from the shields was like
 looking into a fire.’

- (12) Karlamagnúss saga 199,16

... *Kong-s dottir rodna-þi miðg vid*
 king-GEN.SG daughter.NOM.SG blush-3SG.PRET very.much at
þess-a sǫgu ok vard því likuz sem þa
 this-ACC.SG story.ACC.SG and become.3SG.PRET therefore like as then
er roda-r fyrir vpprennandi solu i
 when gleam.red-3SG.PRS while rise.PTCP.PRS.DAT.SG sun.DAT.SG in
hinu fegursta heidi
 the.ART.DAT.SG beautiful.SUPERL clear.sky.DAT.SG
 ‘The king’s daughter blushed very much at this story and (she) therefore
 then became as when it gleams red while the rising of the sun in its most
 beautiful clear sky.’

The two forms in question are *roðaði* ‘(the rock) gleamed red’ (3SG.PRET) in (11) and the impersonal *rodar* ‘it gleamed red’ (3SG.PRS) in (12). In Old West Norse, only the class II weak verbs show a vowel *-a-* in the middle syllable of the present and preterit forms, whereas the class III verbs have no such vowel in the preterit nor *-i-* in the present, cf. *vakti* (3SG.PRET), *vakir* (3SG.PRS) from *vaka* ‘to be awake’.

Formally, *roða* could continue both a class II and class III verb, but the durative/essive semantics rather point to a class III verb that secondarily has adopted class II inflection.

5.9 *svartr* ‘black, dark’

Let us finally have a look at the verbal derivations of the word for ‘black, dark’. OWN *svartr*, Goth. *swarts*, OE *sweart*, OHG *swarz* indicate that it continues PG **swarta-* (EWGP 574).

While an already PG factitive **swartijan-* ‘to make black/dark, blacken/darken’ can be reconstructed on the basis of Goth. *swartjan**, OHG *swerzen* as well as ODan. *swertæ* and OSwed. *svæta*, the West Norse word is attested no earlier than in ModNorw *sverte* (Bjorvand & Lindeman 2019: 1222).

In contrast, class II verbs are attested in OWN only. Here we have another *nan*-verb with zero-grade root, i.e., *sortna*. Again, the ONP does not offer a translation, but the other dictionaries agree on anticausative-inchoative semantics:

- CV: ‘to grow black’
- WAP: ‘schwarz, dunkel werden’
- OngS: ‘sortne, antage en sort Farve’ (‘to become black / blacken, take on a black color’)

(13) Cecilíu saga 284,4

... *dagr-inn* *fly-di*, *ok sol* ***sortna-di***, *ok*
 day.NOM.SG-DET leave-3SG.PRET and sun.NOM.SG **blacken**-3SG.PRET and
ger-di *myrk-t i heim-inum* *aull-um*
 make-3SG.PRET dark-N in home-DAT.PL.DET all-DAT.PL
 ‘... the day left and the sun **blackened** and made all homes dark.’

More interesting, however, is *sorta*. According to ONP and LP this class II verb is sparsely attested in Old Norse prose, but at least four times there and once in the poetic texts. While WAP and ONP, again, offer no translation, a look in the other dictionaries does not reveal contradictions:

- CV: ‘to dye black’
- OsgN: ‘formørke’ (‘to turn sth. black/dark; to eclipse’) (tr.)
- LP: ‘to tar’

as ‘to provide with ointment’. The same is true for Goth. *gapaidōn*, a derivative of *paida* ‘garment’, best paraphrased as ‘provide with garment’ (Krahe & Meid 1969: 239) or OWN *dúka*, a derivative of *dúkr* ‘cloth, veil, scarf’ and therefore ‘to provide with a *dúkr*’ (Iversen 1923: 178). These class II verbs have been termed ‘ornative’ (recently Filatkina 2018: 250; Schaefer 1984: 376–378), and this is key to understanding *sorta* as well. For example, in contrast to OWN *dóma* ‘to judge, pronounce a judgement’, a class I derivative of *dómr* ‘judgement, verdict’, ornative verbs do not denote the realization or materialization of what is denoted in the derivational basis, but that something or someone is provided with the feature or property that the derivational basis has. This means that *sorta* conveys a meaning ‘to provide with blackness’, rather than a meaning ‘to make black, to blacken’. As the difference is not as clear cut as, for example, in **salbōn*- (‘to provide with ointment’ vs. hypothetical *‘to make/turn into ointment’), constellations like these might have contributed to the collapse of the morphosyntactic system of the Germanic weak verbs.

Let us now see if this interpretation can hold up in the light of another example:

(15) Konungs skuggsjá 60,29

... *En þo ero pannzar-ar hofuð vapn til*
and but be.3PL.PRET shield-NOM.PL main weapon.NOM.SG for
lifð-ar a skip-um gorv-ir af blaut-um
protection-GEN.SG on ship-DAT.PL make-PTCP.PRF.NOM.PL of soft-DAT.PL
lerept-um oc vel sorta-PTCP.PRF.DAT.PL godð-ar
canvas-DAT.PL and well **sorta**-PTCP.PRF.DAT.PL good-NOM.PL
hialm-ar oc hang-anða stalhufur.
helmet-NOM.PL and hang-PTCP.PRS.NOM.PL steel.hood-NOM.PL
‘But shields are the main protective weapons on the ships, made of soft
and well-**blackened** canvas, good helmets and low-reaching steel hoods.’

It is a reasonable assumption that the canvas is the one that is ‘provided with blackness’ and that the participle consequently means ‘blackened’.

6 Conclusion

Let us now wrap up the most important findings. Class I verbal derivatives are attested for three out of the eight BCT that I have discussed here: OWN *bleikja*, *grønask*, and – in lack of an OWN cognate – ODan. *swertæ* resp. OSwed. *sværta*.

All of them are at least of Proto-Germanic origin and, according to the dictionaries, express factitive semantics.

The situation is the opposite with regard to the class II *nan*-verbs. For OWN *blána*, *grána*, *hvítna*, *roðna*, *sortna*, and *brúna** (which can be assumed to have existed based on the adjective *brúnaðr* ‘brown colored’), no Germanic cognates are attested. This group was highly productive in OWN, and it is doubtful that any of these words are old.²³ All of them express anticausative-inchoative semantics.²⁴

The remaining three verbs *blika*, *roða*, and *sorta*, despite being class II verbs, differ in terms of meaning: The meaning of *blika* and *sorta* is disputed according to the dictionaries consulted in this article. Even when looking at actual attestations, an unambiguous determination in terms of semantics is not possible for *blika*, at least not based on the contexts I investigated. They vacillate between intensive and inchoative (or semelfactive) semantics.

For *sorta*, the two dictionaries consulted in this study that offer a translation (CV and OgnS) are not precise enough in determining its semantic value. With this in mind, the translations suggested in CV and OgnS ‘to dye black, blacken’ should be refined to ‘to provide with blackness’. While this might be considered an artificial differentiation and while it is probably handy to stick to ‘to dye/make black’ in a translation within a wider context, with respect to the derivational history of this word it is preferable to be as precise as possible in order to be able to understand how the semantic change may have come about.

Finally, synchronically *roða* is a class II verb as well, but its essive/durative semantics suggest that historically it is an old *ēn*-verb that was integrated into class II in OWN.

None of the weak verbs formed to adjectives for BCT in Old West Norse is a member of the third class, which has become highly productive in OHG in forming inchoative verbs (e.g., *fūlēn* ‘to rot or to decay’, *altēn* ‘to become or to grow old’).

²³According to Gorbachov (2007: 114–115) it is unclear how and if OWN *hvítna* is related to Lith. *šviūta* (Inf. *švisti*) ‘become light, start shining’. The long vowel in the OWN form could be explained as the result of leveling with its base *hvitr*, but the consonants do not match. No mention is made of this connection in ALEW s.v. *švisti*. Gorbachov (2007: 116) also shows that OWN *roðna* is a perfect formal match to OIr. *roindid* [sic!] ‘reddens, dyes (with blood)’ and Ved. *ruṇáddhi* ‘restrains, keeps back’, but the latter may very well represent a different PIE verbal category altogether since they have a different (transitive-terminative) function. As Stefan Höfler (p.c. 17.01.25) has furthermore informed me, *roindid* is rather Middle Irish with analogous palatalization of the cluster *-nd-*. For the OIr. form see HÖFLER & STIFTER, this volume, Section 2.2.

²⁴Ottósson (2013: 346): “At least the bulk of the deadjectival [verbs] seems to have denoted types of events that were typically agentless [...]”

We know from corpus studies on the other Old Germanic languages that the word forming verbal suffixes exhibit a functional variety already in the earliest texts (see fn. 4). Along these lines, Schwerdt (2008) has shown that the Old High German verbal classes are often ambiguous with respect to their semantic roles. This is the case for about 60% of *jan*-verbs, 50% of *ōn*-verbs, and 50% of *ēn*-verbs. This ambiguity, however, is not found within Old West Norse, at least to this degree.²⁵ In other words: The system of the Old West Norse weak verbs was intact (although it is clear that it could never have been completely consistent) to a degree that change of state verbs could not function as stative verbs and *vice versa* as they can in Old High German, i.e., they either denote ‘to be x’ or ‘to become x’. However, if and to which degree this might be an artifact arising from working with dictionaries – which do not describe the semantic differences adequately – rather than corpora, is something that deserves to be fleshed out in future studies.

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Abbreviations

Av.	Avestan	OFris.	Old Frisian
Goth.	Gothic	OHG	Old High German
Langob.	Langobardic	OIr.	Old Irish
Lat.	Latin	OS	Old Saxon
Lith.	Lithuanian	OSwed.	Old Swedish
MHG	Middle High German	OWN	Old West Norse
MLG	Middle Low German	PG	Proto-Germanic
ModNorw.	Modern Norwegian	PIE	Proto-Indo-European
ODan.	Old Danish	PN	Proto-Norse
OE	Old English	Ved.	Vedic

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²⁵Boldt (2025).

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